

Caricature Analogies Help Us Explain Things to Ourselves

We can use caricature analogies to help us understand a situation we find ourselves in, a thought we are having, a sudden feeling triggered by an event, and so forth. In such cases, the caricature may reveal or set in sharp relief a conceptual skeleton of which we had been only fleetingly aware. Such analogies, rather than being created to show somebody else something, are created for ourselves alone. A familiar example will demonstrate how the explanation of some phenomenon — in this case, an explanation that a driver comes up with — can come about thanks to analogies that one manipulates.

As any San Franciscan knows only too well, parking in Baghdad by the Bay is always hellish. One night, though, in the wee hours of the morning, as E. was driving home through downtown San Francisco, he suddenly had a surreal sensation. On Market Street, where it's normally hopeless, he saw empty spots left and right. All around Union Square, perhaps the city's most nightmarish zone, were dozens of parking places crying out to be taken. And as he arrived in his own neighborhood, always jam-packed with cars, his gaze was met with vacant spots galore. E. felt mounting outrage as he stared at these priceless gems for which any driver would have given their eyeteeth and yet for which he had no use at all. Should he simply stop and park in one of them, to savor this astonishing godsend? No, that would be too silly... E. realized he had no choice but to resign himself to letting these amazing rarities (which in this case were a dime a dozen) sail by untouched, one treasure after another. It gave him little consolation to think that in just a few hours, all these streets would once again be clogged to the gills, obliterating this improbable sight.

E. tried to understand more deeply just why he felt so frustrated to see all these "lovely spots". A few analogies came to mind and helped him out. He said to himself that these spots were like a mountain of gold in front of someone who had no tools to extract even the tiniest nugget from it, or like the discovery in an attic of a huge fortune in banknotes no longer accepted as legal tender. Next, he imagined himself utterly stuffed after wolfing down a mediocre meal and then having to decline a whole series of delicious gourmet courses brought to the table.

As he continued ruminating, E. decided that what he was seeing was not so precious after all. He started coming up with happier analogues: "This is like being admitted for free into the city's trendiest nightclub moments before it closes, when no one wants to be there any more, and the last few souls there all drunk as pigs and looking sickly in the bright glow of the overhead lights that have been turned on for the cleaning service that's about to arrive." Then again, "This is like being given free access to the Fillmore Auditorium the morning after the Rolling Stones perform there, when the place is totally empty." And also, "This is like being on a secluded tropical island, normally the playground of billionaires, but in monsoon season." In this fashion, a new vision emerged in E.'s mind: rather than being hugely frustrated by vast riches before him that he couldn't touch, he was now simply in a terrific place but at a terrible time to be there.

We see that caricature analogies can help us strip a new situation down to its core, shedding fresh light of all sorts on it, bringing out in the open one or more conceptual skeletons that were vaguely lurking in the shadows when the situation first arose. Such caricatures spring spontaneously from the “halo” of rapid generalizations that any new scenario of interest tends to evoke in the mind of a curious person, and they help reveal the conceptual skeleton at the root of such generalizations.

In this case, two different types of caricature analogy allowed E. to take two possible perspectives on the situation he was facing. The first type, mapping the empty spots onto treasures that seem ripe for the taking but that are inaccessible due to an unfortunate combination of circumstances, helped him to understand just why, as a San Francisco driver, he was so frustrated. Tending to reinforce his initial impression, these first caricatures had little pedagogical use, but at least they allowed him to see a bit more clearly why he was feeling so unlucky. In contrast, the second wave of caricature analogies, as their common underlying conceptual skeleton started emerging into the light, helped him find a happier way of looking at things. His plight was now mapped onto various scenarios in which timing is everything: all these lovely spots, totally available because it was in the middle of the night, were like concert tickets after a great concert is over. Different essences can thus be brought out by different caricatures.

The Best Ones are Always Snatched up First

A caricature analogy can sometimes clarify subtle phenomena that at first came to mind only as intuitions without any clear logic to them. When one runs through a number of caricatures, the hidden conceptual skeleton that one had only vaguely sensed at the outset starts to come out into the open much more clearly.

To see this, let’s consider a paradox that users of big-city bicycle rental systems (such as are found in Washington, Miami, Montreal, and a few other North American cities, as well as in various other cities around the world) have almost surely all noticed. Rentable bicycles are locked to long racks in many parts of the city; with a credit card or membership card, you can unlock one, ride it here or there, and then leave it, locked once again, in another rack, where other people will be able to use it in turn. But alas, one soon notices that there is scant cause for joy when one walks up to a rack where there are only a few bikes left. Indeed, chances are high that they’re all defective, so the rack is as good as empty. Contrariwise, when a rack is full, one generally has a wide choice among many bikes in great shape. At first, this fact about nearly-empty racks might seem surprising, for it involves a “double penalty”: not only are there fewer bikes to choose among, but adding insult to injury, the few that are there are almost sure to be unusable. Thus a rack’s bike-sparseness is doubly rough on any hopeful rider who arrives, since sparseness is also a sign of defectiveness. You may already have figured out why this phenomenon, rather than being surprising, is in fact to be expected; if so, more power to you. But if you don’t see it yet, then you might appreciate some help in identifying a much more general phenomenon of which this bike-renting paradox is just one particular example.